Righteousness

Living as God's Righteous People

You foolish Galatians! Who has cast a spell on you? Before your eyes Jesus Christ was vividly portrayed as crucified! The only thing I want to learn from you is this: Did you receive the Spirit by doing the works of the law or by believing what you heard? Are you so foolish? **Although you began with the Spirit, are you now trying to finish by human effort?** (Galatians 3:1-3)

https://tinyurl.com/RightWithGod

Rejecting the Righteousness of Man and Living as God's Righteous People

Central theme:

Even believers can drift back into self-made righteousness, but God calls His people to reject self-trust, receive His righteousness by faith, and display that righteousness together as a holy community.

Gal 3:1-9 You foolish Galatians! Who has cast a spell on you? Before your eyes Jesus Christ was vividly portrayed as crucified! (2) The only thing I want to learn from you is this: Did you receive the Spirit by doing the works of the law or by believing what you heard? (3) Are you so foolish? Although you began with the Spirit, are you now trying to finish by human effort? (4) Have you suffered so many things for nothing? – if indeed it was for nothing. (5) Does God then give you the Spirit and work miracles among you by your doing the works of the law or by your believing what you heard? (6) Just as Abraham ***believed God, and it was credited to him as righteousness***, (7) so then, understand that those who believe are the sons of Abraham. (8) And the scripture, foreseeing that God would justify the Gentiles by faith, proclaimed the gospel to Abraham ahead of time, saying, "***All the nations will be blessed in you***." (9) So then those who believe are blessed along with Abraham the believer.

The Ongoing Danger
Human Righteousness Still Appeals to Believers

Philippians 3:4-9 *... If someone thinks he has good reasons to put confidence in human credentials, I have more: (5) I was circumcised on the eighth day, from the people of Israel and the tribe of Benjamin, a Hebrew of Hebrews. I lived according to the law as a Pharisee. (6) In my zeal for God I persecuted the church. According to the righteousness stipulated in the law I was blameless. (7) But these assets I have come to regard as liabilities because of Christ. (8) More than that, I now regard all things as liabilities compared to the far greater value of knowing Christ Jesus my Lord, for whom I have suffered the loss of all things – indeed, I regard them as dung! – that I may gain Christ, (9) and be found in him, not because I have my own righteousness derived from the law, but <u>because I have the righteousness that comes by way of Christ's faithfulness – a righteousness from God that is in fact based on Christ's faithfulness.</u>*

Galatians 3:1–3 shows the danger of starting by the Spirit but trying to continue by the flesh.
Philippians 3:4–9 shows Paul rejecting every ground of personal confidence so that Christ alone remains his righteousness.

- Self-made righteousness is <u>not only</u> an unbeliever's problem.
- Even believers can begin in dependence on God and then slowly return to dependence on effort, performance, and control.
- Subtle forms of legalism, pride, comparison, and self-trust can re-enter Christian life.

The Ongoing Danger: Human Righteousness Still Appeals to Believers

The Great Contrast
Two Righteousnesses – Two Ways of Living

Romans 10:2-4 *For I can testify that they are zealous for God, but their zeal is not in line with the truth. (3) For ignoring the righteousness that comes from God, and seeking instead to establish their own righteousness, they did not submit to God's righteousness. (4) For Christ is the end of the law, with the result that there is righteousness for everyone who believes.*

- Shows the tragedy of trying to establish our own righteousness instead of submitting to God's.

Matthew 5:20 *For I tell you, unless your righteousness goes beyond that of the experts in the law and the Pharisees, you will never enter the kingdom of heaven!*

- Shows that true righteousness must go beyond outward religious performance.

The main issue is not whether a person is religious, but whether he is trusting himself or trusting God.

- The righteousness of man: self-trust, works, performance, pride
- The righteousness of God: grace, faith, Christ, new life

That is the danger. A person can be serious, religious, and sincere, and still miss God by trying to build their own righteousness. So, we live between these two paths every day.

- One path says, "prove yourself." The other says, "trust Christ."
- One leads to pride or despair. The other leads to humility and life.

The Great Contrast: Two Righteousnesses

Every person lives under one of two kinds of righteousness.

The first is the **righteousness of man**. This is built on self-trust. It depends on performance. It measures worth by effort, comparison, and outward behavior. It often leads to pride when we think we are doing well, and discouragement when we know we are not. This is the righteousness of the scribes and Pharisees. It looks strong on the outside but cannot stand before God.

The second is the **righteousness of God**. This does not come from us. It comes from Him. It is given by grace, received through faith, and grounded in Christ. It does not begin with what we do, but with what Christ has done. From there, it produces a new life that actually changes how we live. Jesus said:

Matthew 5:20 "For I tell you, unless your righteousness goes beyond that of the experts in the law and the Pharisees, you will never enter the kingdom of heaven!"

He was not calling for more rule-keeping. He was pointing to a different kind of righteousness altogether. Paul explains the failure of Israel this way:

Romans 10:3-4 "For ignoring the righteousness that comes from God, and seeking instead to establish their own righteousness, they did not submit to God's righteousness. For Christ is the end of the law, with the result that there is righteousness for everyone who believes."

The call is simple: stop establishing your own righteousness. Submit to God's.

Depend on Him daily. Not just at the beginning of faith, but all the way through. The same grace that saves is the grace that sustains. Walk in it.

Why Human Righteousness Always Fails

Because of where it comes from…

Man trying to fix himself…

- Moralism (be a good person)
- Legalism (rule-based righteousness)
- Religious identity (belonging instead of transformation)
- Self-improvement worldview (modern version)

Why these world-views fail…

- **Rom 8:6-8** *For the outlook of the flesh is death, but the outlook of the Spirit is life and peace, (7) <u>because the outlook of the flesh is hostile to God</u>, for it does not submit to the law of God, nor is it able to do so. (8) Those who are in the flesh cannot please God.*

They all share the <u>same foundation</u>:

- **Man is the source of his own righteousness**.
- Human righteousness fails because it is rooted in the flesh.
- It may look disciplined, moral, or serious, but it cannot produce peace with God or true holiness.
- It produces either pride when we think we are succeeding, or despair when we know we are not.
- It shifts the Christian life away from Christ and back onto self-measurement.
- This is why self-righteousness remains spiritually dangerous even inside the church.

Moralism (be a good person)
This is the most common view.
People believe:
- if i do enough good
- if i avoid major wrongs
- if i try hard
- then i will be accepted by God.

This sounds reasonable. Even respectable.
But the problem is deeper. Scripture says: "for all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God" (Romans 3:23, NET)

The standard is not "better than others."
It is God's own righteousness.

Moralism lowers the standard to something man can manage.
But that standard is no longer God's. Result:
- outward effort
- inward guilt
- no real peace

Legalism (rule-based righteousness)
Legalism tries to solve the problem with structure.
- Add rules. Add discipline. Add boundaries.

This can even look very serious and committed.

But it shifts focus:
- from Christ → to performance
- from grace → to measurement

Paul warns about this drift: "Having begun by the Spirit, are you now trying to be made perfect by the flesh?" (Galatians 3:3, NET)
Legalism creates two outcomes:
- pride ("i'm doing better than others")
- or despair ("i can't keep this up")
- Either way, Christ is no longer the center.

Religious identity (belonging instead of transformation)
Some trust in:
- church background
- family history
- theology knowledge
- outward association

This was Israel's struggle. "They are ignorant of God's righteousness and seeking to establish their own" (Romans 10:3, NET)

The assumption:"i belong, therefore i am righteous."
- But belonging does not equal new life.

Result:
- confidence without change
- familiarity without holiness

Self-improvement worldview (modern version)
Today, this shows up as:
- personal growth
- discipline systems
- mindset optimization

The belief is: "i can become who i need to be through effort and learning."
- This can produce real change at a surface level.

But it cannot deal with:
- sin nature
- guilt before God
- separation from Him
- It improves behavior, not the heart.

Why all of these fail

They all share the same foundation: **man is the source of his own righteousness**

- That is the core issue.

Scripture is clear:

- “the mindset of the flesh is hostile to God, because it does not submit to the law of God, nor is it able to do so” (Romans 8:7, NET)
- Not just unwilling — unable.
- So even our best efforts:
- cannot reach God’s standard
- cannot change our nature
- cannot produce true holiness

The deeper problem

- Human righteousness is not just “insufficient.”
- It is **misdirected trust**.

It says:

- look at what i am doing
- measure me by my effort
- accept me based on my performance

But the gospel says:

- look at Christ
- trust what He has done
- receive what you cannot produce

Why this is dangerous in the church

This does not stay outside. It creeps inside.

A person can:

- believe the right doctrine

- attend faithfully
- serve actively

and still quietly measure themselves by:

- consistency
- discipline
- comparison to others

This shifts the center.

- Instead of: resting in Christ's righteousness
- they begin: managing their own
- That leads to: subtle pride ("i'm doing well") or quiet despair ("i'm falling short again")

What True Righteousness Requires

A Different Source – Not Self, but Christ Jesus

Rom 3:21-24 *But now apart from the law the righteousness of God (although it is attested by the law and the prophets) has been disclosed – (22) namely, the righteousness of God through the faithfulness of Jesus Christ for all who believe. For there is no distinction, (23) for all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God. (24) But they are justified freely by his grace through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus.*

Only the righteousness that comes from God can stand…

- Because it starts with Christ alone. Received, not built. Rooted in Christ, not self.
- It can reach God. It can change the heart. It can give peace.

God's Righteousness Must Be Received Daily

- God's righteousness is not something believers graduate from after conversion.
- It remains the ground of their standing and the source of their life every day.
- The Christian life is not sustained by self-improvement, but by ongoing trust in Christ.
- Daily dependence means returning again and again to grace rather than performance.
- This keeps repentance, humility, and gratitude central.

What true righteousness requires:

- Not improvement.
- Not effort.
- But a different source.

God's righteousness is:

- given, not earned
- received, not built
- rooted in Christ, not self

Every human worldview that tries to produce righteousness ends the same way:

- it cannot reach God
- it cannot change the heart
- it cannot give peace
- because it starts with man.
- Only the righteousness that comes from God can stand
- because it starts with Christ.

God's Purpose Is Bigger Than the Individual

The Church Must Not Repackage Human Righteousness

1 Peter 2:9-12 But you are *a chosen race*, *a royal priesthood*, *a holy nation*, *a people of his own*, so that you may *proclaim the virtues* of the one who called you out of darkness into his marvelous light. (10) You once were ***not a people***, but now you are God's people. You were ***shown no mercy,*** but now you have received mercy. (11) Dear friends, I urge you as foreigners and exiles to keep away from fleshly desires that do battle against the soul, (12) and maintain good conduct among the non-Christians, so that though they now malign you as wrongdoers, they may see your good deeds and glorify God when he appears.

Titus 2:11-14 For the grace of God has appeared, bringing salvation to all people. (12) It trains us to reject godless ways and worldly desires and to live self-controlled, upright, and godly lives in the present age, (13) as we wait for the happy fulfillment of our hope in the glorious appearing of our great God and Savior, Jesus Christ. (14) *He gave himself for us to set us free from every kind of lawlessness and to purify for himself a people who are truly his, who are eager to do good.*

God's righteousness received by faith produces the holy people that human righteousness can never create.

- The church is not called to display moral pride, but God's character.
- God's righteousness in community is seen when people live in holiness without self-exaltation. With Grace, Humility, Mercy, Obedience, and Love.

God's Purpose Is Bigger Than the Individual

- God is not merely producing righteous individuals in isolation; He is forming a righteous people together.
- The church becomes a visible witness to what God's righteousness looks like in shared life.

The Church Must Not Repackage Human Righteousness

- A community can still become self-righteous if it builds its identity on comparison, rule-keeping, status, or control.
- So, this lesson should stress that the church is not called to display moral pride, but God's character.
- A grace-shaped community shows humility instead of superiority, mercy instead of boasting, and obedience flowing from love rather than fear.
- God's righteousness in community is seen when people live in holiness without self-exaltation.

The Daily Call: Live Between the Two With Discernment

- Every believer lives with a daily contrast:
    - trust in self or trust in Christ
    - performance for acceptance or obedience from acceptance
    - pride in personal righteousness or gratitude for God's righteousness
- The Christian life requires discernment because the righteousness of man often disguises itself as maturity.
- The answer is not less holiness, but deeper dependence on God.

One Unified Gospel

God’s Plan to Restore His Human Family

The Gospel Narrative

- Christ reveals God’s righteousness.
- Justification receives God’s righteousness.
- New birth implants God’s righteousness as new life.
- Sanctification expresses God’s righteousness in character and conduct.

Key Contrasts

- Not human achievement, but divine provision.
- Not works as the basis, but faith as the means.
- Not outward conformity alone, but inward transformation.
- Not a one-time decision only, but a life continually shaped by grace.

Summary

- God’s righteousness is revealed in Christ, credited through faith, planted in us by the Spirit, and lived out in holiness.
- The believer does not move beyond grace after conversion; he grows deeper into it.